

# THE CROSSROADS



Celebrating 50 years of  
Chinmaya Yuva Kendra

## GIRLS IMPACT



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**TRAVEL DIARIES**

Hiya Deep Dave

**THE POWER WITHIN HER**

Nandini Khemka – Girl Up Mahattva, CIRS

**HARNESSING YOUTH POTENTIAL THROUGH DYNAMIC SPIRITUALITY**  
**THEME OF THE YEAR 2025**

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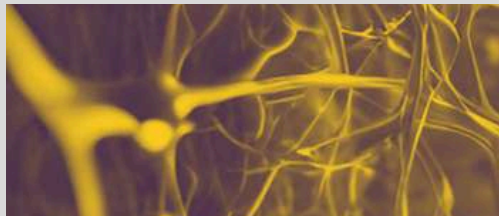
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# NEURO PLASTICITY

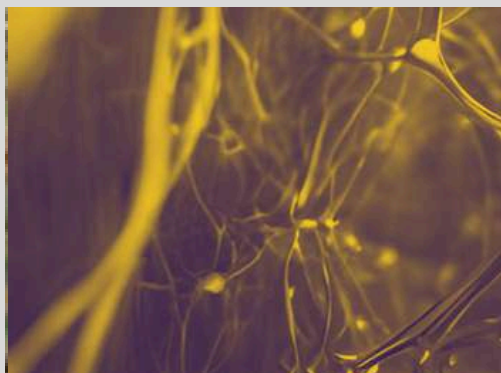
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Neuroplasticity, as defined by the American Psychological Association, is the capacity of the brain to change through the making and breaking of synaptic connections between neurons caused by both genetic and environmental factors. N-E-U-R-O-P-L-A-S-T-I-C-I-T-Y is a mouthful for any of us to say and comprehend, but to put it simply, neuroplasticity is an umbrella term that compares our brain to a BIG ball of clay that can be molded by external or internal factors. Here, plasticity refers to our brain's malleability and does not literally mean plastic. Neuroplasticity can involve functional changes due to brain damage or structural changes due to learning, causing drastic changes in neural networks in our brain.

Shockingly, the human brain is composed of 86 BILLION NEURONS and it's widely believed that the creation of new neurons stops soon after birth. And researchers concur; the synaptic connections in a fetal brain are TWICE the number of connections an adult brain has!

As we grow older, we gain many new experiences, strengthening some connections while eliminating others in a process called neural 'pruning'. Besides this, it's important to know that our brain is not infinitely malleable. Hence, parts responsible for certain specialized functions are so important that they cannot be replaced. Damage to these key areas can result in crippling deficits. While some recovery may be possible, the remaining areas of the brain can never fully take over the functions that were affected by the damage.



Now, let me introduce you to one of the greatest pioneers in neuroplasticity-related research - Eleanor Maguire. In 2000, Maguire and her team of researchers decided to test their hypothesis on neuroplasticity with the help of London black cab taxi drivers. One difference between London taxi drivers and our very own autorickshaw drivers is the strenuous exam the former must give, called the 'Knowledge of London', to obtain a license. In this test, they would quite literally be questioned on every single landmark and route in London. Now imagine how many synaptic connections would be completely reorganized in their brain after their preparation process! Maguire wanted to examine exactly this: whether structural changes could be detected in the brains of taxi drivers with extensive experience of spatial navigation.

For their sample, they chose 16 right-handed London taxi drivers that had been driving for more than 1.5 years. For comparison, they had a control group of 50 other right-handed males. Structural MRI scans were taken of both groups, compared and analyzed. The researchers observed more grey matter in the brains of the London taxi drivers (grey matter is a tissue in our brain that processes and interprets information). This led them to establish a positive correlation between the amount of time spent as a taxi driver and the volume of grey matter present. The conclusion implied was that a mental map of London was stored in the brains of the taxi drivers and accommodated by an increase of tissue volume in their brains. At that time, this study intrigued the minds of several psychologists and is probably pretty mind-boggling for us students as well.

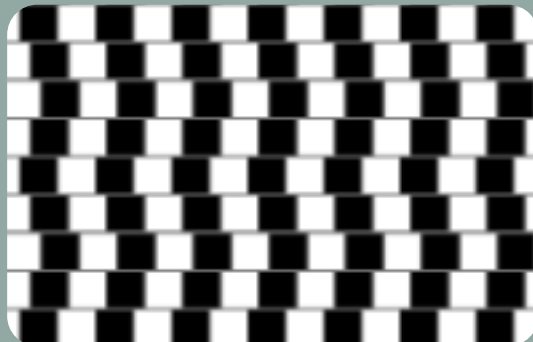


Being a psychology student, neuroplasticity as a concept intrigues me to no end, but ultimately promises more than just subjective knowledge or abstract theories. It also simply means change behind those very, very complicated terms. Isn't it shocking how 100 million neurons in our brains are willing and able to change and adapt to the situations around us? So what stops us then? How much does the fear of change haunt our every action? How difficult is it for us to consciously eliminate the things pulling us down in our life, and embrace that which uplifts us? What we usually do not see is how letting go is only the first step of growth. So practice letting go of the painful past, of anxiety about the uncertain future, of self-doubt regarding your abilities. A baby develops into an adult when its billions of neurons transform into millions of neurons after absorbing new experiences of learning. Neuroplasticity goes even further. Attesting to how imperative it is for us to break out of our shells and try out things beyond our comfort zone. Walking out on our duties is just an excuse made out of fear, a decision that puts a lid on our true potential. It's time we finally start to accept and adapt to the changes in our life, thereby turning our hidden potential into visible performance through neuroplasticity.

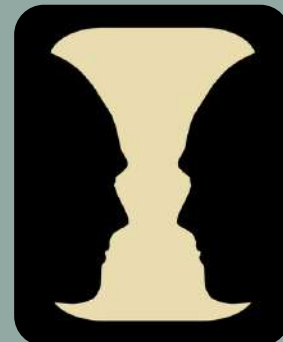
But are you confused as to how exactly you can put what you learnt about the hidden power of neuroplasticity into action? Puzzles and riddles, learning new languages or skills, creating art, playing music and exercising are all simple things you can work into your daily schedule to unlock this mental superpower. But why look far when your friendly neighborhood Crossroads Team has got you covered? Read on for a couple of mind-boggling optical illusions that will give your brain a real workout. Good luck!



Just a bowl of vegetables? Turn the picture upside down and look again!



Do the lines seem to bend? They are actually parallel!



Do you see a vase or two faces?



# WHY EVERYBODY LOVES CARTOONS

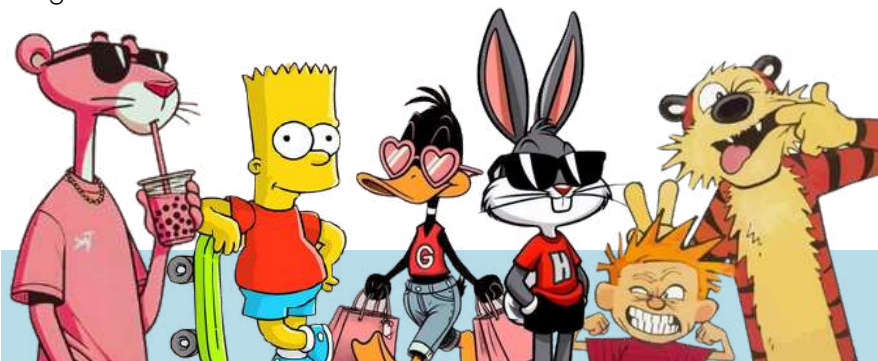
DEVIKA DHELIA | GRADE 8, CIRS

Imagine waking up one fine day and finding yourself surrounded by people you only remember from hazy childhood memories. Although the world seems completely different from what you know, a sudden thought strikes you: you've definitely seen this place somewhere before... maybe on the television... or in a book?

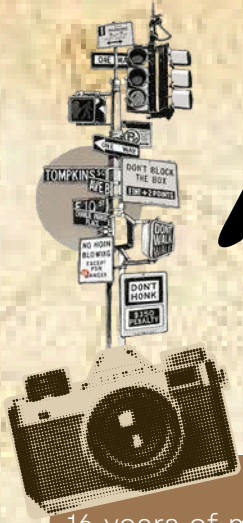
Welcome to the amazing and fun-filled world of cartoons. A world where you don't have to know a math formula or what atoms are. The only sound you can hear is the laughter and giggles of everybody around. Can you remember when we were all toddlers just sitting around and watching cartoons? Those days when cartoons were the topmost priority for all of us and studies were probably the last? Maybe even now, some of us secretly wish that we could sit with all our loved ones during the vacations and take a chill pill by watching some cartoons.

The best part about cartoons is that they are not as intricate as Shakespeare's literature, they never ask you to find the surface area of a cube, or balance a chemical equation. We may become bored of studying, but watching or reading cartoons always sends a thrilling rush of dopamine through our body.

All of us think that cartoons are all about fun, entertainment, vibrancy, color, etc. But what if I tell you that very important messages or news are also spread through this creative method? After all, are not social, political and moral messages regularly spread through cartoons too? They ensure the mood of the audience remains light and happy. One such cartoon that appears regularly in all established newspapers is Calvin and Hobbes, a light-hearted take on the world as seen by a precocious kid. In fact, a key term that we can pick up from this statement is 'newspaper'. We read the newspapers everyday, but do we see the short and sweet cartoons in them? Undoubtedly, my favorite pastime is thronging around the newspaper stand during juice breaks trying to get a glimpse of at least one of those cartoons and having a good laugh about them for the remainder of the break.



As we enter our teenage years, we end up losing the spark in our eyes, we start to perceive cartoons as lame and cringe. Thus, we increasingly choose watching series and movies over indulging in joyful cartoons. If we watch such movies because we think of them as symbols of adulthood, or to portray a more mature or grown up version of ourselves in front of our peers, it clearly displays how we only want popularity for ourselves. Even as we grow up, let us never forget all the memorable cartoons that were literally our life when we were kids. Even when we become 60 years old, let us remain childlike and remember those golden days of watching and reading cartoons. So the next time you land on the cartoons page while flipping through the newspaper don't hesitate to stop and laugh out loud with your old friends from younger days.



# Travel Diaries

HIYA DEEP DAVE | 11 MGMT, CIRS



16 years of my life and more than 25 road trips across India; each one a unique capsule bursting with the culture, nature, history and life of the beautiful place. Having travelled thousands of miles across the length and breadth of this beautiful country, I have realized that there is so much more to travel than just the tourist destinations that we tend to visit. Ultimately, each path traversed gave me the opportunity to learn and carefully weave together every new discovery into a colorful piece of vibrant art. Throughout the journey, there were many cherished moments of joy, sadness, excitement and perhaps most importantly, lasting self unfoldment.

I have realized travel is not only about being fascinated by exploring new places. Travel is also about sheer spontaneity that teaches you to adapt to diverse situations that come your way. Also, every place you visit has a hidden story to tell - but only if you're willing to listen. These stories will end up shaping you into something that you never thought you could ever be. After all these trips, one thing that I can confidently say is that whether consciously or unconsciously, the experiences you gain while travelling will give you insights into who you truly are. And that's exactly why I'm writing this article: to give you a glimpse into the surprising shifts in perspective that a lifetime of travel can give you. Ready? Let's get started.



Driving along the highway at the crack of dawn, one can see the sun painting its brilliant hues of pink across the sky. The sun rises everyday and radiates its warmth all around, enhancing the beauty of each and every component of the environment. It slowly shines brightly enough to light up the whole world and provides energy to all. As the sun sinks it starts getting colder and colder, and finally darkness falls. Just like that, we too have moments of warm sunshine and cold darkness in our lives. But with consistent positive affirmations we can slowly start lighting up the darkness of our lives. Then there comes a moment of pure joy when the sun is right above our head, bathing us in its warmth. But there are always factors which seek to pull us down, negative affirmations that make us doubt our own capabilities. When we face these in our lives, we must remember the maxim of 'this too shall pass'. Thus, travel teaches us that just as the sun always rises to dispel the darkness, we too must learn to overcome the negativity in and of our lives.



As the night sets in we all scurry into our cozy beds and snuggle under our blankets, but neglect the potential beauty the night may hold. Travelling during the day truly reveals the beauty of nature; but while being around all the trees, flowers, insects and so much more, we tend to sideline night travels as we feel they would be unsafe. Only when one actually travels in the night does one realize the beauty the night truly possesses. The glistening moonlight in the sky, the twinkling stars, all make it seem as though the whole world was celebrating Diwali. It seems as though fireflies have emerged into the night, emanating all around, as though we were living in a fairy tale. When one attentively observes and notices all that is around them without any biased opinions, does one truly understand the calmness and serenity the night holds. Open your eyes and eliminate the ignorance within; look at the world and situations around you with a new perspective. Only then can we experience the vast range of places we have left to explore.





Haven't all of us spent cherished moments with our cousins and relatives during long journeys? The interactions and bonds I have formed while on road trips are ones that will stay with me for life. These memories remind us to truly admire the smallest of things around, and build a completely new attitude towards life. Seeing the language, culture and nature changing every kilometer or so, helps one internalize the fact that change is constant. Ensuring you stay in the present and treasure every moment of joy you experience. Thus, every path travelled by us requires a different mindset, and travel teaches you how to cultivate exactly that.

Just like the sun, the moon, the stars, the grass, the sun's rays and every other small element, the totality of nature has its very own role and responsibility towards the world around it. Thus, travel teaches us the true value of ourself, and with every passing moment we learn to take up new responsibilities and see the world in a way which we never knew we could.

# A ROLE MODEL

RIDDHI SINGHANIA | GRADE 8, CIRS

A role model, a bright light;  
A person who we think is right.  
A person to follow day and night,  
Helping your dreams to take flight.

A soul who constantly inspires;  
As important as the wind that whispers.  
A person whom we admire,  
Giving us the motivation we require.

A person whom we all know;  
A role model, who helps us grow.





# FLOW STATE

NAMBURU VENKATA DHEERAJ | II SCI, CIRS

Have you ever felt so immersed in an activity that you completely lost track of time? Until you suddenly snapped out of it after a while, only to be shocked at how well you performed? If yes, then congratulations because you have unconsciously unlocked the realm of flow state! Flow is a mental state wherein there is huge input of information from past experiences to our brains due to intense focus. Boosted by our intense concentration and data inflow, our latent potential is unleashed through heightened performance in the face of a challenging situation.

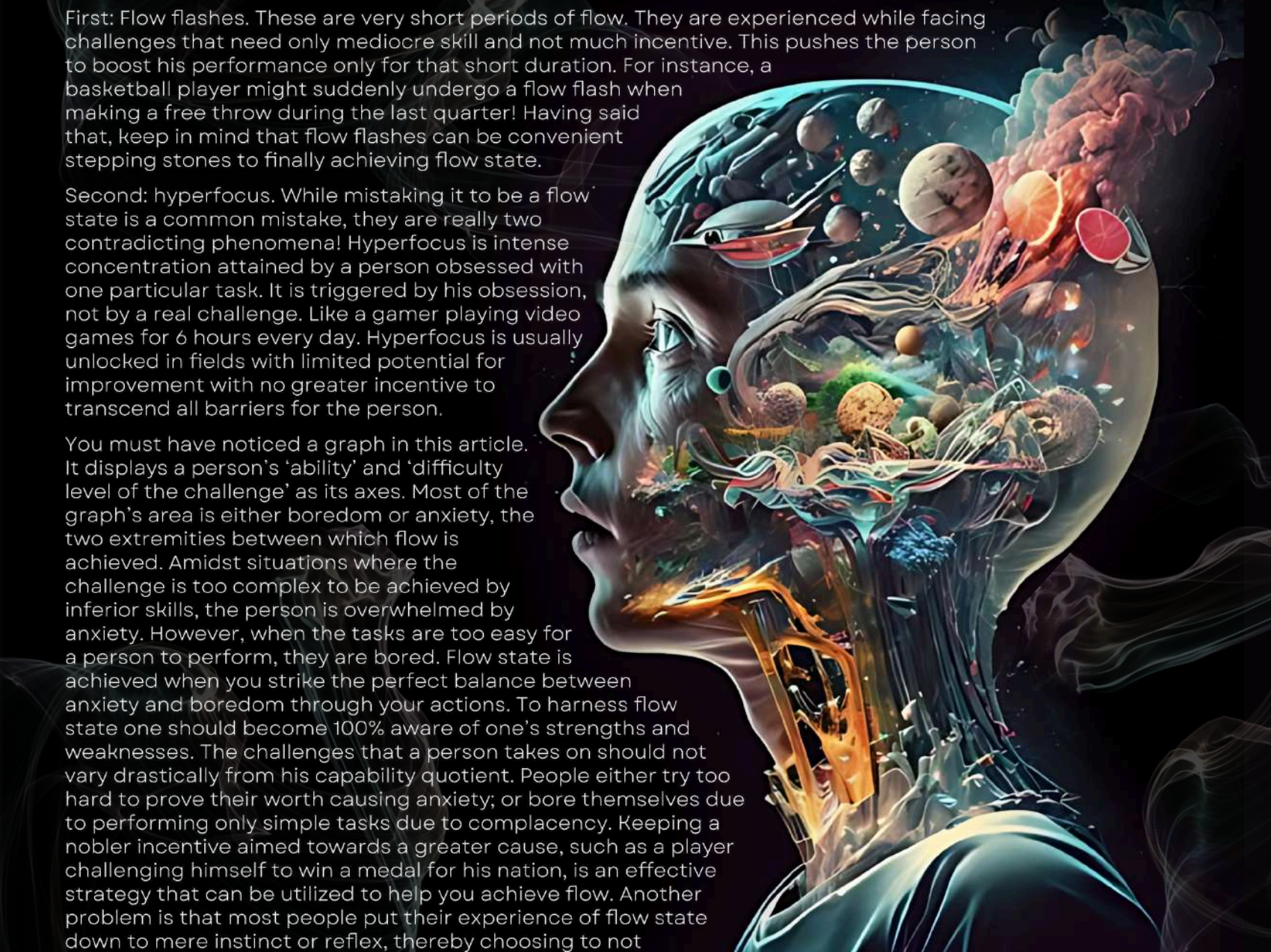
Further examining this term, one may misunderstand it to be a new age phenomenon discovered in hi-tech laboratories. However, there's nothing that could be further from the truth. The term flow state was actually coined way back in 1975 by Mihal Csikszentmihalyi - a Hungarian-American psychologist. As he happened to notice the peculiar behaviour of painters when they were engaged in their paintings. Amazingly, they appeared to forget about their sleep, food and all other needs while creating a masterpiece. He observed this intriguing behavioural attribute in many artists, and named his discovery 'flow state'.

However, haven't we felt in the certain times that we have, in fact, experienced a state at least close to flow? Those times when we were really at the top of our game? Well, it is highly likely that you have met the real flow state's evil twins: flow flash and hyperfocus. Let me explain to you what they are.

First: Flow flashes. These are very short periods of flow. They are experienced while facing challenges that need only mediocre skill and not much incentive. This pushes the person to boost his performance only for that short duration. For instance, a basketball player might suddenly undergo a flow flash when making a free throw during the last quarter! Having said that, keep in mind that flow flashes can be convenient stepping stones to finally achieving flow state.

Second: hyperfocus. While mistaking it to be a flow state is a common mistake, they are really two contradicting phenomena! Hyperfocus is intense concentration attained by a person obsessed with one particular task. It is triggered by his obsession, not by a real challenge. Like a gamer playing video games for 6 hours every day. Hyperfocus is usually unlocked in fields with limited potential for improvement with no greater incentive to transcend all barriers for the person.

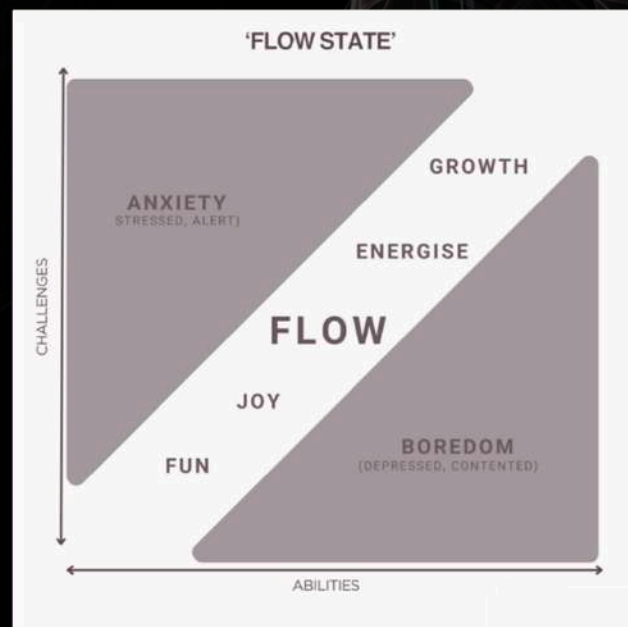
You must have noticed a graph in this article. It displays a person's 'ability' and 'difficulty level of the challenge' as its axes. Most of the graph's area is either boredom or anxiety, the two extremities between which flow is achieved. Amidst situations where the challenge is too complex to be achieved by inferior skills, the person is overwhelmed by anxiety. However, when the tasks are too easy for a person to perform, they are bored. Flow state is achieved when you strike the perfect balance between anxiety and boredom through your actions. To harness flow state one should become 100% aware of one's strengths and weaknesses. The challenges that a person takes on should not vary drastically from his capability quotient. People either try too hard to prove their worth causing anxiety; or bore themselves due to performing only simple tasks due to complacency. Keeping a nobler incentive aimed towards a greater cause, such as a player challenging himself to win a medal for his nation, is an effective strategy that can be utilized to help you achieve flow. Another problem is that most people put their experience of flow state down to mere instinct or reflex, thereby choosing to not



manifest it repeatedly. The reason for this is that the brain produces alpha and low-level beta waves in flow state. Beta waves are produced when the brain is thinking, and alpha waves are produced when the brain activity is relaxed. A natural balance of both leads to flow. Studies on the famous Brazilian footballer Neymar Junior revealed that his brain activity drops drastically during a game. This shows that he enters an intense state of flow each time, which definitely explains his flawless dribbling skills! Even Kobe Bryant described his physical and mental state during his career high 81 point game as his body and mind working in complete harmony.

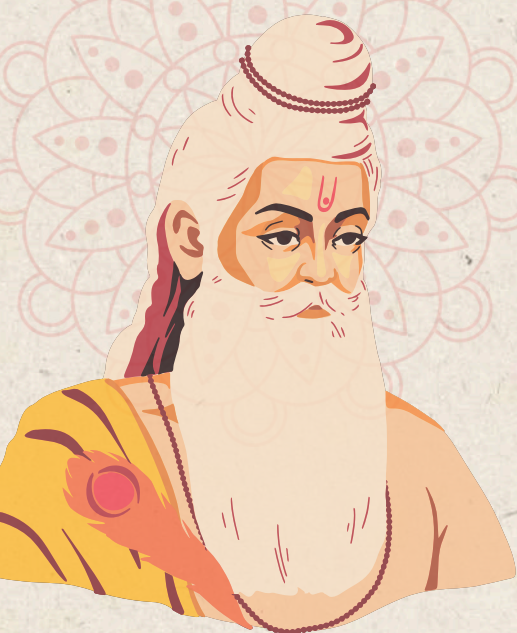
At this point let me give you all a disclaimer: flow statement is not something that can be achieved easily! To consciously experience it a person must have skills that he is confident about and a short-term task which tests and challenges his abilities. In case of flow, however, an enticing field of unlimited potential inspires the person to constantly improve, fostering development. Ultimately, it is solely through dedicated

Ultimately, it is solely through dedicated practice of a particular task that interests, inspires and challenges you that the state of flow can be achieved. Thus, through this article, I wish to urge everyone to try their best to attain the ability to flow smoothly through all of life's tough times. But don't forget to regularly take a moment to pause and appreciate the progress you've made along the way, for that's what flow is all about - process, not destination!



# The Great Cities

SAKET KALYANI | GRADE 10, CIRS



In the Valmiki Ramayana, Sage Valmiki describes Ayodhya in great detail in the Balakanda. He writes that the people possessed different instruments and weapons, and that the city itself was a sprawling structure spread over 12 yojanas in length and 3 yojanas in width - one where skilled artisans had erected arched gateways, well-decorated local markets and beautiful buildings. It was built based on the Ashtapada design, in which the palace had highways on all four sides to ensure no space was wasted, and was adorned with multiple gardens and trees.

At the other end of Bharat, the towers of Lanka rose tall and proud. In the Sundarakanda, it is mentioned that the city had been built by Vishvakarma. When Hanuman ji enters Lanka in search of Mother Sita, he is faced with a fortified citadel atop a mountain, well guarded by ramparts with spiked iron tridents and moats brimming with water, and shataghnis (a type of missile). There were yellow-white palaces neatly whitewashed, well-laid streets decorated with garlands, mansions of seven to eight storeys, and beautiful quadrangles covered with crystal grains that made it seem as though they were floating. The whole place was filled with the soothing calls of cranes, peacocks and swans.

These were just two of the great cities of Bharat. Like these, numerous cities flourished across the subcontinent that exemplified the vast knowledge Bharat possessed in terms of engineering and architecture. These are present in the books like Sthapatya Veda, Vastu Shastra and Narada Shilpasashtra. However, in today's day and age, our cities have degraded from the marvelous cities of the past. They are now strewn with pollution, exploitation of resources, land degradation, poverty, etc. It is the need of the hour to take immediate steps towards fixing this by learning from the past and using the knowledge we gain to create the future we all want to see for Bharat.

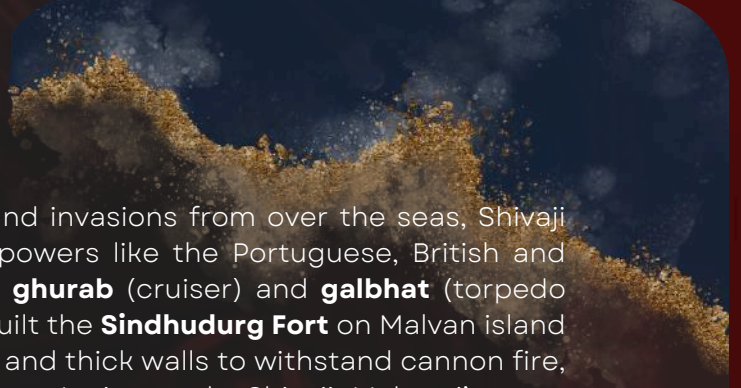
# 5 FACTS ABOUT CHHATRAPATI SHIVAJI MAHARAJ

*Chetk*



## Navy:

Recognizing that a strong navy was necessary to withstand invasions from over the seas, Shivaji Maharaj raised a formidable force to challenge foreign powers like the Portuguese, British and Siddis. His fleet included over **300 warships** such as the **ghurab** (cruiser) and **galbhat** (torpedo boat) for **swift and deadly** attacks. Not only that, he also built the **Sindhudurg Fort** on Malvan island in the Arabian Sea. With secret passages, freshwater wells and thick walls to withstand cannon fire, this unique fort stood tall before any maritime intruder. At its peak, Shivaji Maharaj's navy **dominated** the Konkan coast, cutting off enemy supply lines and crushing invasions. Shivaji Maharaj's maritime achievements made him a terror to his enemies, and earned him the title of **'Father of the Indian Navy'**.



## Forts:

Having grown up amidst the lofty mountains of the Deccan plateau, Shivaji Maharaj knew the hilly terrain like the back of his hand. During his battles with the Mughals, he used this knowledge to capture and build a vast network of over **240 fortresses** in his lifetime. These helped him to attack the Mughals where they least expected it, vanish into the thick forests, and reappear safe in one of his inaccessible forts.

To the hapless Mughals he seemed like a **ghost** who tormented them at will, so much so that his nickname in Aurangzeb's court was **'mountain rat'**. True marvels of ancient engineering, these stone bastions were built with rock and lime mortar, and were filled with **wells**, granaries, living quarters, hidden traps and imposing walls with slits for archers and cannons.



## Samarth Ramdasji:

Shivaji Maharaj's spiritual guru, **Swami Samarth Ramdas** is among Maharashtra's most venerated saints till date. But besides his association with Shivaji Maharaj, Samarth Ramdasji is also known for his contribution to Bharat's freedom. He traversed the length of Bharat for **12 long years** to understand the attitude of the people, and wrote many compositions, both devotional and patriotic. His fiery writings inspired countless revolutionaries and thinkers who succeeded him including **Vinayak Savarkar** and **Lokmanya Tilak**. Even today, Swami Ramdasji's rich legacy lives on through the **11 Hanuman temples** he established across Maharashtra to inspire the people.





# Policies:



Unlike many kings who focused solely on conquest, Shivaji Maharaj was also an exceptional administrator who established an **efficient, swift** and **just** governance system. His rule was based on fairness, discipline and people's welfare. Shivaji Maharaj always punished corrupt officials and rewarded **merit** over caste or birthright. He abolished the **jagirdari** and **zamindari** tax systems, and introduced **ryotwari** (direct revenue collection) to ensure farmers weren't overtaxed. Amazed yet? There's more to come! Just like King Ashoka and Akbar, Shivaji Maharaj also had a council of **8 wise men** called the '**Ashta Pradhan**' that advised him in key areas like finance, defense and foreign policy. Additionally, Shivaji Maharaj is also well known for his military and diplomatic tactics and policies, so much so that **Boston University** actually has a course on him entitled 'Shivaji, the Management Guru'!



# Marathi and Sanskrit:

॥ सर्वे भवन्तु सुखिनः  
सर्वे सन्तु निरामयाः ॥

At a time when Bharat's kings were surrendering before the Mughals in order to retain their kingdoms as mere puppet rulers, Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj stood up and united his people into an efficient fighting force. But his battle was not for the land alone, it was also for Bharat's ancient **culture** and **heritage**. And what better way to protect it than by safeguarding its languages? Thus, Shivaji Maharaj is famous for promoting the use of Sanskrit and Marathi in his kingdom. All **official announcements** and **court records** were kept in Sanskrit and Marathi, and **state patronage** was provided to these languages.

# CHHAAVA

A Cinematic Triumph Honoring Chhatrapati Sambhaji Maharaj

The life and times of Chhatrapati Sambhaji Maharaj - the fiery second leader of the Maratha empire - have long been hidden in the glorious aura of his equally illustrious father Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj. But such a tale of valour and indomitable resistance cannot be ignored for long and it is only natural that this great son of Bharat has finally been paid an epic tribute through Laxman Utekar's recent film Chhaava. Aptly titled (Chhaava means 'lion's cub'), the 2 hour 35 minute cinematic masterpiece astounds both visually and intellectually. With its thrilling war scenes, stirring patriotic moments, intense dialogue delivery and heart wrenching climax, Chhaava is a must watch for all those eager to know more about Chhatrapati Sambhaji Maharaj and the Maratha empire. Most importantly, the filmmakers have done well by staying true to the facts, not taking unnecessary creative liberties and portraying all facets of Sambhaji Maharaj's life equally well. Overall, Chhaava is a film that is sure to enchant and inform the people of Bharat about one of their own - a great king and greater man who left behind a legacy that will inspire millions to come.



# OUR PLANET:

KHUVI SARAWGI | GRADE 8, CIRS

The mountains reach up high into the sky.  
Rivers flow down them with such a cry,  
Nourishing the dark canopies of lush green trees.  
Upon whose sweet flowers sit thousands of bees.  
This is the sublime beauty of Mother Nature,  
The supreme wonder of all God's creatures.

# THE FINAL FALL

PRADYUM TIBAREWAL | II MGMT, CIRS

The flora and fauna from which you  
were born,  
The beauty you hold and we adorn.  
Is it that you have quietly forgone?  
Will it be a new day or man's last dawn?  
Let it be a timely warning for all,  
Or prepare for man's final fall.

# KUMBH MELA



Kumbh Mela from the air

Also, all the tourist expenses including stay, food and pooja samagri generate an immense amount of revenue in the form of GST. Lots of revenue has also been generated through services provided starting from buses, shuttle and car rentals to parking charges.

Spillover effect is seen in any event that indirectly affects other areas. In the case of the Maha Kumbh Mela, spillover effect took place when people who came with a motive to visit Maha Kumbh, also showed up at nearby places like Ayodhya's Ram Mandir, temples in Kashi Vishwanath and many more. Also, 3000 crores of corporate investment has made the Maha Kumbh Mela the second largest mega event in India after the IPL.

Then comes the concern that all our hard-earned taxed money is being used. But it's not a waste of resources, it's rather a strategic investment. The returns on this investment are substantial and far-reaching as they help the Uttar Pradesh government with infrastructural development, tourism promotion, reduction in unemployment and much more.

The Maha Kumbh Mela, an event of phenomenal global proportions, symbolizes spiritual cleansing for pilgrims across the world. The event attracts millions of devotees, saints, and pilgrims and in fact, this religious gathering will witness more pilgrims than the combined population of Canada and the USA. All the "red" that we see in the adjoining image is thousands of devotees clad in the auspicious colors of red and saffron, clustered on the banks of Prayagraj. However, there exists a narrow outlook regarding ANY RELIGIOUS EVENT (PARTICULARLY THE KUMBH MELA) that they are a drain on economic resources. But we're here to flip that narrative.



Moreover, the Kumbh Mela catalyzes technological advancement. For instance, we're deploying cutting-edge technology to greatly support the flow of this massive event. AI-enabled cameras and drones which are present even underwater, will help monitor crowd flow and ensure safety. Digital wristbands and mobile app tracking, with the full consent of participants, will help track the movement of pilgrims more efficiently. Now, think about the implicit actions of these technologies. They're not just for the Kumbh Mela, they have applications in urban planning, disaster management, and numerous other fields. The innovations developed for this event will have a ripple effect, benefiting India and potentially the world.

The Kumbh Mela is a testament to the power of cultural events that drive economic growth and technological innovation. It's not a drain on resources; it's an investment for our future. It's a demonstration of how we can leverage our rich cultural heritage to create opportunities, generate revenue, and advance technology. It's a symbol of India's cultural dynamism and commitment to progress.

Kumbh Mela, an event of cultural significance to the Hindus, serves as an economic powerhouse that would make Wall Street jealous! Think of Kumbh Mela as the world's most unexpected business convention, where ancient traditions meet modern world economics and business.

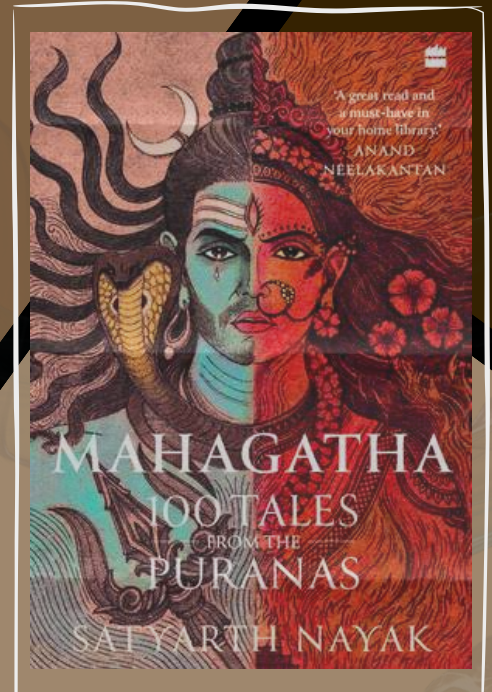
The ongoing Maha Kumbh Mela in Prayagraj in 2025 is projected to generate revenues of Rs 25,000 crore. But that's not all! The overall GDP growth is estimated to reach a staggering Rs 3 lakh crore.

# Crossbusters

## MAHAGATHA: 100 TALES FROM THE PURANAS

Our scriptures are a vast universe of wisdom, embodying the quest for knowledge that is central to Hinduism. This eye-opening anthology of tales rich with symbolism and import is a roaring testament to the timeless lessons of our Puranas in particular. Affirming that the ancient knowledge encoded in Bharat's literary tradition - both written and oral - is neither dead nor dying, the book shows us how it lives and how it still has something to do for the human people.

Presenting to you 'Mahagatha: 100 Tales from the Puranas'. An enchanting anthology of tales known and unknown retold by Satyarth Nayak, a well-known author and screenwriter best known for his novel 'The Emperor's Riddles' and the epic television series 'Porus'. The collection marks an important landmark in bringing to light hidden tales that are woven into the very fabric of Bharat's culture. For instance, do you know the story where Brahmaji and Vishnuji race against each other or when Vishnuji saves an elephant? Do you know about Maya Sita or why Suryaji falls from the sky? Many such fascinating tales have been ably handpicked and compiled by Nayak and presented in this epic illustrated edition.



Mahagatha also provides a sneak peek into the minds of devas, devis, asuras and humans alike, pursuing a deeper line of enquiry that seeks to understand the real motivations of the characters. Additionally, the entire compilation has been arranged in a never-before-seen chronological format - beginning from the Satya Yuga and ending with the advent of Kali Yuga. This unique order makes for continuous reading, revealing that these stories are actually linked to each other in the grand scheme of events. Written in engaging prose with charming illustrations, this anthology will make you connect the dots of itihaas like never before.

## Grade XII Farewell

Dear Grade XII, the month that all of us thought would never arrive is finally upon us. In a matter of weeks, we have seen you transform into confident and powerful academic go-getters. We wish you the best results in your exams. Looking back at all the moments we've spent together, we know that they will forever remind us of you and the love, talent and cheer you spread throughout CIRS. As you step out into the world now as confident young adults, we wish you the utmost success in wherever life takes you from here.



# The Power Within Her

NANDINI KHEMKA | 12 MGMT, CIRS

All alone, far from her nest,  
She lives the life of a warrior,  
Moving with utmost caution.  
Every glance a lash, every choice questioned,  
Every move judged and every word silenced.

No matter the fabric, no matter the fit  
She will always be criticized,  
Whether it's a crop top or a baggy tee.  
Held back by the chains of partiality and bias,  
Her dreams remain shattered and  
The light around her dimmed.

Her laughter is that of the devil's  
While boys' loud joys are just "boys being boys".  
Her happiness is locked, and the key lost.  
They preach the way a girl should be  
Knowing little that she aims for the endless sky.

Equality was a promise but  
Turned out to be a lie in disguise.  
When she tries to rebel,  
She is met with dire consequences which  
She does not deserve.

Yet the flames of defiance persist deep in her heart,  
Despite the system's double standards that keep her framed.

She yearns to rise and bounce back;  
She stands unbowed, with the heart of a phoenix -  
Burning with the urge to break free and fly high.

She is the storm that blows quietly.  
Her heart burns with a purpose;  
Every passing day, it becomes brighter.  
Soon, she alone will burn the world around her,  
The world that holds her back.

Now, she fears not the shackles.  
Instead, with every step she takes,  
She melts away the chains of imprisonment  
And crumbles the walls keeping her hostage.  
She is turning out to be the embodiment of  
"FREEDOM" itself.

After all, she is a warrior living in a golden cage:  
Her so-called 'home', living the life of expectations.





# CALISTHENICS

RISHI CHOTHAN | IB I YEAR, CIRS

Weird word, isn't it? The word itself comes from Greek with 'Kalos' meaning beautiful and 'Sthenos' meaning strength. The origin of calisthenics dates back all the way to 600 B.C where Spartan warriors used it as part of their military training. It was lost for a long while and finally made its comeback in the early 1800s when it was brought into the education sector and popularized as an 'acceptable' form of exercise for women. Although initially intended solely for women, the results of this new form of exercise astounded many and it was soon adopted by all ages and sexes. Now, even the US army has incorporated this ancient strength training technique into its soldier training regimes. In addition to weight lifting, soldiers should perform one to two calisthenics circuits per week to maintain their performance.

Calisthenics is a form of strength training that really only requires one piece of equipment: you. No dumbbells, no weights, no bands; just you. Furthermore, the beauty of calisthenics is that it can be practiced almost anywhere so you can't conjure up any excuses. You can do it at the park, atop a tree or even at the peak of Mount Everest. A calisthenics workout plan for beginners would look a little like this. (Please keep in mind that this is not meant to set a standard for beginners, but is only a rough outline of where regular practice can get you).

Push ups (2 sets of 10)  
Squats (3 sets of 10)  
Plank (30 seconds)  
Mountain climbers (30 seconds)  
Leg raises (2 sets of 15)

You might think, "Oh, nothing too crazy, just the basics." But I tell you this from personal experience: never underestimate the foundational exercises. You will find those thirty seconds of the plank the longest thirty seconds of your life, the push-ups excruciatingly painful and the leg raises will have you wishing for a new set of less broken abdominal muscles. The thing is, every single aspect can be modified according to your skill level. For example a year ago I was unable to do even one push up. So I started with an easier version of them: knee push-ups. I practiced the 'Bring Sally Up' challenge consistently and eventually worked my way up to one regular push-up. Now they're a part of my warm up routine. Thus, consistency is really the last word in successfully practicing calisthenics to achieve a fit body.

But when there are so many other alternatives to body-building like weight-lifting or gymnastics, why would you even pick calisthenics? First of all, the absence of equipment lowers the risk of injury down to minimal because people generally recognize their own boundaries. Moreover, with calisthenics, you can safely push your limits both mentally and physically. Through lower impact exercises paired with high repetitions, you begin to truly test yourself. Perhaps most importantly, besides building muscle and strength you also build your mind. Sticking to a calisthenics routine regularly also cultivates the discipline to stick to something and stick to it good. As once you start getting that fulfillment you'll never stop. You'll keep going until you reach wherever it is you want to.





So my friends, this is what calisthenics truly is. Your body is meant to be flexible and mobile. To build that flexibility and mobility, you have to work with your body and mind together. You need to be able to catch yourself when you slip, and you need to have that rigor to work towards something. So you see that while a big part of calisthenics is building muscle and strength, it's also about building you as a whole. The qualities you gain from practicing calisthenics will translate into your everyday life, building the discipline and resolve needed in the real world. Don't you think that if everyone started doing some kind of workout the world would be a better place? There surely wouldn't be as many diseases floating around. Obesity would begin to disappear and nations would have strong, disciplined individuals empowered by the ability and will to change the world. After all, when the solution is right in front of us, why do we not follow it? Especially when the path has already been traced by so many before us. Let us try and switch over to a healthier lifestyle for ourselves. Let us become the changemakers we're destined to be. Let us try and explore the beauty of calisthenics starting today.

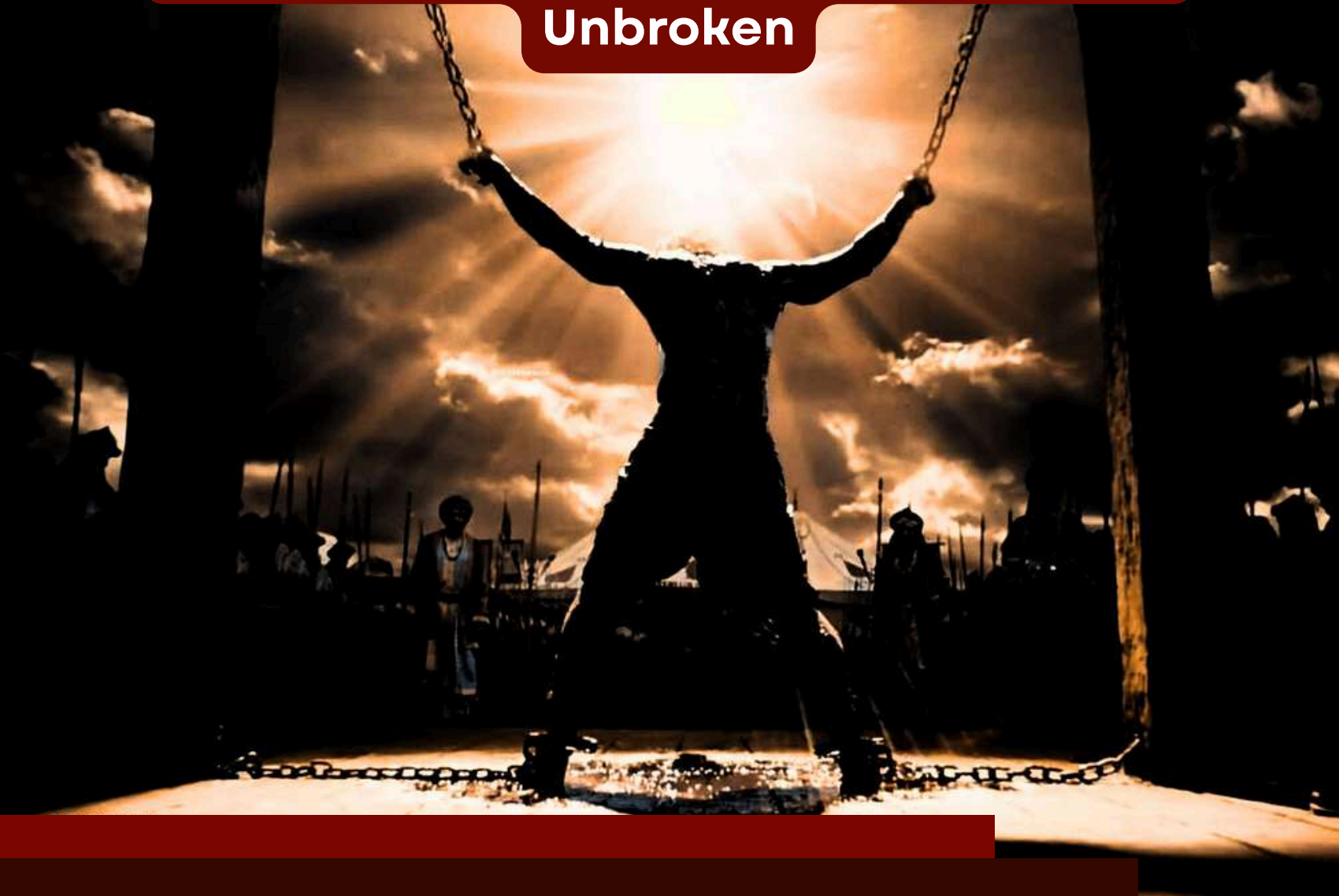
Another reason why you should pick calisthenics is its astounding versatility. Personally, I started doing calisthenics because I didn't want to head over to the gym every single day. I fell in love with the freedom it offered – being able to workout anywhere, with nothing but my bottle of water, using just my body weight. I was pretty young when I started calisthenics so there was also this one silly thought that really drove me to stick to my routine. I thought about hanging off a cliff's edge using just my hands. Ridiculous, right? But every few weeks, whenever I felt like skipping my workout, I used to go back to that seemingly impossible wish and ask myself how badly I wanted it. This is what kept me strong. This is what kept me going. Maybe with a few tweaks, it could help you stay motivated too.



## GRADE 10 GET-TOGETHER

Dear Grade X, your undying optimism, great sense of humor and daredevil shenanigans have earned you a lasting place in all our hearts. To all those who are walking past our gates, your presence will be sorely missed in the days to come at CIRS. As we bid adieu to some of you and welcome many others back to our fold as the future leaders of CIRS, we thank you for the memories we have made and will forever cherish, and wish you all the best for everything you take up in the future.

# Echoes of Chhaava - Unbowed, Unbent, Unbroken



The salt stung deep, the blood ran free,  
Nails torn out, but weakness was not to be.  
No kingly robes, no jeweled grace,  
But scars etched deep on his brow and his face.

His eyes, once bright, now hollowed wells,  
Of blood and pain, yet one wonders how nothing tells  
Of broken spirit, crushed and low,  
In his gaze, we yet see a fiery glow.

Around him stood the fearful throng,  
Their king's unease, a silent song.  
He feared a warrior, bound and bare,  
A mountain's strength, beyond compare.

Neither a whispered plea, nor a trembling sign,  
Just regal calm, a truth I'm yet to divine.  
They took his sight, they maimed his frame,  
But couldn't touch his spirit's immortal flame.

The sun may die, the moon may break,  
The earth may tremble, mountains shake,  
But in that heart, a fire burned,  
A Hindu spirit, alive, alert and undeterred.

Through unfathomable darkness, deep and vast,  
His vision upright, his spirit steadfast  
A light that pierced the tyrant's crown,  
A legend born, as though a deity come down.

Sambhaji's name, a whispered prayer,  
Ma Bhavani's Grace, the source of his power.  
A totem of resilience, faith, and might,  
In the darkest of nights, a star, that still shines, bright

*Sambhaji  
Chaitanya*

*An ode to our Chhaava*

# Captures







# CREATIVE CORNER



Aarush K. ~ V 🐣



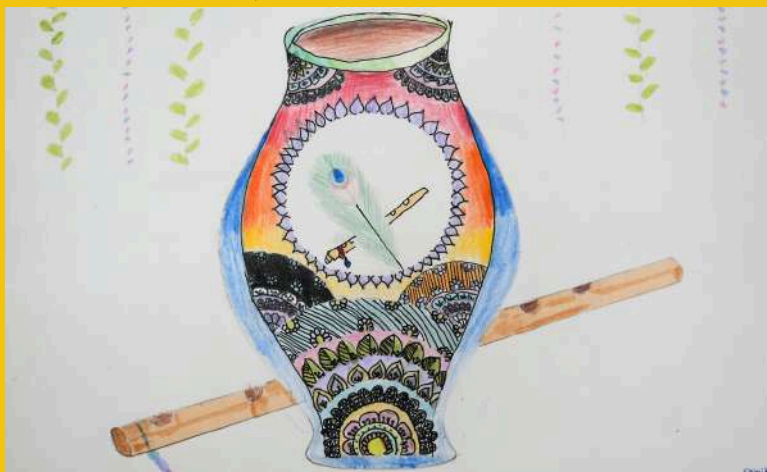
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Arav ~ VIII 🐣



Lavanya K. ~ VIII 🐣



Srinika ~ V 🐣



Shakthi C. ~ VIII 🐣



Trisha ~ V 🐣



Devansh S. ~ VII 🐣



Nakshatra G. ~ VII 🐣



Kushagra A. ~ V 🏆



Siddhant J. ~ VIII 🏆



Tanay L. ~ VII 🏆



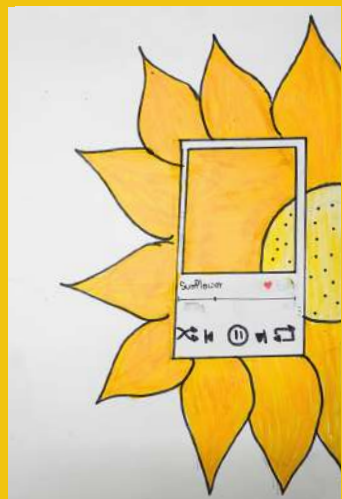
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Stuti R. ~ V 🏆



Stuti B. ~ V 🏆



Naman T. ~ VI 🏆



Aarush S. ~ VII 🏆



Vedant A. ~ VI 🏆



Vyan G. ~ VII 🏆



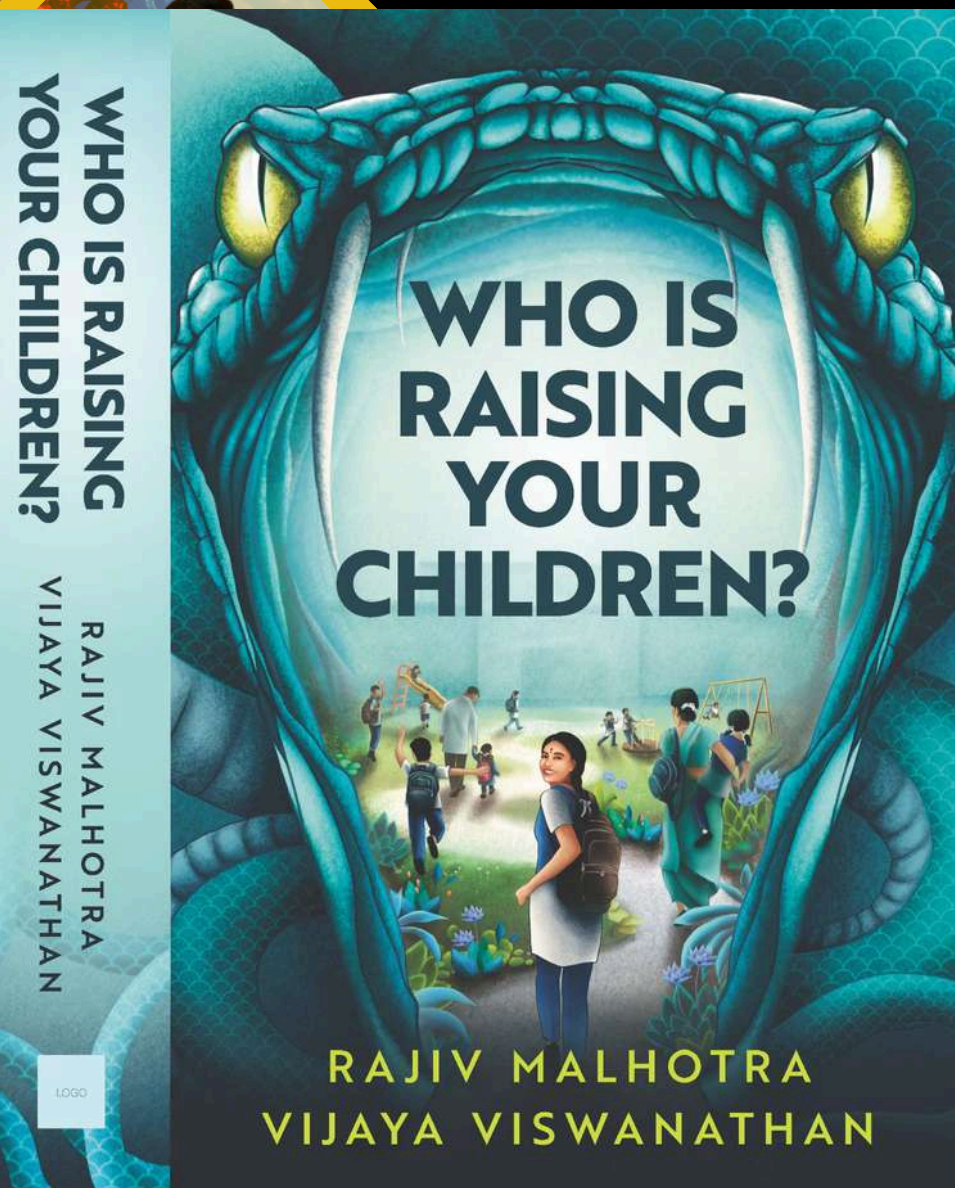
Arth A. ~ VII 🏆



V. Pirai Soodan - VII 🏆

Prayer is the only resort to the individual who has fully realized the emptiness of his hollow vanities in the presence of the Mighty Total, the Supremely Divine.

February 2025 | Living the Vision of the Visionary through Devotion



The book cover features Aghasura from the Bhagavata Purana, symbolizing the hidden dangers of Western education models being adopted in India. Key points include:

The UN's Sustainable Development Goals 2030 influence global education, embedding ideological agendas like global citizenship and social justice.

Countries like China and Russia focus on education from their own civilizational perspectives, unlike India, which follows Western frameworks without scrutiny.

India adopts Western ideologies in Comprehensive Sexual Education and Global Citizenship Education, potentially compromising traditional values.

The book warns Indian policymakers to learn from the failures of the US K-12 system to avoid similar pitfalls.

It advocates for Indian educators to resist foreign pressures and realign education with Bharatiya heritage and values for the benefit of Indian children.

